

'Now,' said he, 'I hope monsieur will not give me the pain of not taking any supper. Dinner has already been refused; this is affronting to the house of les Medici. Look, monsieur, the supper is on the table, and I venture to say that it is not a bad one.'

The unknown asked for a glass of wine, broke off a morsel of bread, and did not stir from the window whilst he ate and drank.

Shortly after was heard a loud flourish of trumpets; cries arose in the distance, a confused buzzing filled the lower part of the city, and the first distinct sound that struck the ears of the stranger was the tramp of advancing horses.

'The king! the king!' repeated a noisy and eager crowd.

'The king!' cried Cropole, abandoning his guest and his ideas of delicacy, to satisfy his curiosity.

With Cropole were mingled, and jostled, on the staircase, Madame Cropole, Pittirino, and the waiters and scullions.

The cortège advanced slowly, lighted by a thousand flambeaux, in the streets and from the windows.

After a company of musketeers, a closely ranked troop of gentlemen, came the litter of monsieur le cardinal, drawn like a carriage by four black horses. The pages and people of the cardinal marched behind.

Next came the carriage of the queen-mother, with her maids of honour at the doors, her gentlemen on horseback at both sides.

The king then appeared, mounted upon a splendid horse of Saxon breed, with a flowing mane. The young prince exhibited, when bowing to some windows from which issued the most animated acclamations, a noble and handsome countenance, illuminated by the flambeaux of his pages.

By the side of the king, though a little in the rear, the Prince de Condé, M. Dangeau, and twenty other courtiers, followed by their people and their baggage, closed this veritably triumphant march. The pomp was of a military character.

Some of the courtiers—the elder ones, for instance—wore travelling dresses; but all the rest were clothed in warlike panoply. Many wore the gorget and buff coat of the times of Henry IV and Louis XIII

When the king passed before him, the unknown, who had leant forward over the balcony to obtain a better view, and who had concealed his face by leaning on his arm, felt his heart swell and overflow with a bitter jealousy.

The noise of the trumpets excited him—the popular acclamations deafened him: for a moment he allowed his reason to be absorbed in this flood of lights, tumult, and brilliant images.

'He is a king!' murmured he, in an accent of despair.

Then, before he had recovered from his sombre reverie, all the noise, all the splendour, had passed away. At the angle of the street there remained nothing beneath the stranger but a few hoarse, discordant voices, shouting at intervals 'Vive le Roi!'

There remained likewise the six candles held by the inhabitants of the hostelry des Medici; that is to say, two for Cropole, two for Pittirino, and one for each scullion. Cropole never ceased repeating, 'How good-looking the king is! How strongly he resembles his illustrious father!'

'A handsome likeness!' said Pittirino.

'And what a lofty carriage he has!' added Madame Cropole, already in promiscuous commentary with her neighbours of both sexes.

Cropole was feeding their gossip with his own personal remarks, without observing that an old man on foot, but leading a small Irish horse by the bridle, was endeavouring to penetrate the crowd of men and women which blocked up the entrance to the Medici. But at that moment the voice of the stranger was heard from the window.

'Make way, monsieur l'hôtelier, to the entrance of your house!'

Cropole turned around, and, on seeing the old man, cleared a passage for him.

The window was instantly closed.

Pittirino pointed out the way to the newly-arrived guest, who entered without uttering a word.

The stranger waited for him on the landing; he opened his arms to the old man, and led him to a seat.

'Oh, no, no, my lord!' said he. 'Sit down in your presence?—never!'

'Parry,' cried the gentleman, 'I beg you will, you come from England—you come so far. Ah! it is not for your age to undergo the fatigues my service requires. Rest yourself.'

'I have my reply to give your lordship, in the first place.'

'Parry, I conjure you to tell me nothing; for if your news had been good, you would not have begun in such a manner; you go about, which proves that the news is bad.'

'My lord,' said the old man, 'do not hasten to alarm yourself; all is not lost, I hope. You must employ energy, but more particularly resignation.'

'Parry,' said the young man, 'I have reached this place through a thousand snares and after a thousand difficulties; can you doubt my energy? I have meditated this journey ten years, in spite of all counsels and all obstacles—have you faith in my perseverance? I have this evening sold the last of my father's diamonds; for I had nothing wherewith to pay for my lodgings and my host was about to turn me out.'

Parry made a gesture of indignation, to which the young man replied by a pressure of the hand and a smile.

'I have still two hundred and seventy-four pistoles left and I feel myself rich. I do not despair, Parry; have you faith in my resignation?'

The old man raised his trembling hands towards heaven.

'Let me know,' said the stranger,—'disguise nothing from me—what has happened?'

'My recital will be short, my lord; but in the name of Heaven do not tremble so.'

'It is impatience, Parry. Come, what did the general say to you?'

'At first the general would not receive me.'

'He took you for a spy?'

'Yes, my lord; but I wrote him a letter.'

'Well?'

'He read it, and received me, my lord.'

'Did that letter thoroughly explain my position and my views?'

'Oh, yes!' said Parry, with a sad smile; 'it painted your very thoughts faithfully.'

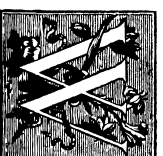
'Well—then, Parry.'

'Then the general sent me back the letter by an aide-de-camp, informing me that if I were found the next day within the circumference of his command, he would have me arrested.'

'Arrested!' murmured the young man. 'What! arrest you, my most faithful servant?'

Chapter VII

Parry



HU!ST the unknown was viewing these lights with interest, and lending an ear to the various noises, Master Cropole entered his apartment, followed by two attendants, who laid the cloth for his meal.

The stranger did not pay them the least attention; but Cropole approaching him respectfully, whispered, 'Monsieur, the diamond has been valued.'

'Ah!' said the traveller. 'Well?'

'Well, monsieur, the jeweller of S. A. R. gives two hundred and eighty pistoles for it.'

'Have you them?'

'I thought it best to take them, monsieur; nevertheless, I made it a condition of the bargain, that if monsieur wished to keep his diamond, it should be held till monsieur was again in funds.'

'Oh, no, not at all: I told you to sell it.'

'Then I have obeyed, or nearly so, since, without having definitely sold it, I have touched the money.'

'Pay yourself,' added the unknown.

'I will do so, monsieur, since you so positively require it.'

A sad smile passed over the lips of the gentleman.

'Place the money on that trunk,' said he, turning round and pointing to the piece of furniture.

Cropole deposited a tolerably large bag as directed, after having taken from it the amount of his reckoning.

‘Oh, monsieur, I hope people are not so dishonest at Blois as you seem to think; and that the diamond, being worth what you say—’

The unknown here again darted at Cropole one of his withering glances.

‘I really do not understand diamonds, monsieur, I assure you,’ cried he.

‘But the jewelers do: ask them,’ said the unknown. ‘Now I believe our accounts are settled, are they not, monsieur l’hôte?’

‘Yes, monsieur, and to my profound regret; for I fear I have offended monsieur.’

‘Not at all!’ replied the unknown, with ineffable majesty.

‘Or have appeared to be extortionate with a noble traveller. Consider, monsieur, the peculiarity of the case.’

‘Say no more about it, I desire; and leave me to myself.’

Cropole bowed profoundly, and left the room with a stupefied air, which announced that he had a good heart, and felt genuine remorse.

The unknown himself shut the door after him, and, when left alone, looked mournfully at the bottom of the purse, from which he had taken a small silken bag containing the diamond, his last resource.

He dwelt likewise upon the emptiness of his pockets, turned over the papers in his pocket-book, and convinced himself of the state of absolute destitution in which he was about to be plunged.

He raised his eyes towards heaven, with a sublime emotion of despairing calmness, brushed off with his hand some drops of sweat which trickled over his noble brow, and then cast down upon the earth a look which just before had been impressed with almost divine majesty.

That the storm had passed far from him, perhaps he had prayed in the bottom of his soul.

He drew near to the window, resumed his place in the balcony, and remained there, motionless, annihilated, dead, till the moment when, the heavens beginning to darken, the first flambeaux traversed the enlivened street, and gave the signal for illumination to all the windows of the city.

‘Yes, my lord.’

‘And notwithstanding you had signed the name Parry?’

‘To all my letters, my lord; and the aide-de-camp had known me at St James’s and at Whitehall, too,’ added the old man with a sigh.

The young man leaned forward, thoughtful and sad.

‘Ay, that’s what he did before his people,’ said he, endeavouring to cheat himself with hopes. ‘But, privately—between you and him—what did he do? Answer!’

‘Alas! my lord, he sent to me four cavaliers, who gave me the horse with which you just now saw me come back. These cavaliers conducted me, in great haste, to the little port of Tenby, threw me, rather than embarked me, into a little fishing-boat, about to sail for Brittany, and here I am.’

‘Oh!’ sighed the young man, clasping his neck convulsively with his hand, and with a sob. ‘Parry, is that all?—is that all?’

‘Yes, my lord; that is all.’

After this brief reply ensued a long interval of silence, broken only by the convulsive beating of the heel of the young man on the floor.

The old man endeavoured to change the conversation; it was leading to thoughts much too sinister.

‘My lord,’ said he, ‘what is the meaning of all the noise which preceded me? What are these people crying “Vive le Roi!” for? What king do they mean? and what are all these lights for?’

‘Ah! Parry,’ replied the young man ironically, ‘don’t you know that this is the King of France visiting his good city of Blois? All these trumpets are his, all those gilded housings are his, all those gentlemen wear swords that are his. His mother precedes him in a carriage magnificently encrusted with silver and gold. Happy mother! His minister heaps up millions, and conducts him to a rich bride. Then all these people rejoice; they love their king, they hail him with their acclamations, and they cry, “Vive le Roi! Vive le Roi!”’

‘Well, well, my lord,’ said Parry, more uneasy at the turn the conversation had taken than at the other.

‘You know,’ resumed the unknown, ‘that my mother and my sister, whilst all this is going on in honour of the King of France, have neither money nor bread; you know that I myself shall be poor and degraded within a fortnight,

when all Europe will become acquainted with what you have told me. Parry, are there not examples in which a man of my condition should himself—'

'My lord, in the name of Heaven—'

'You are right, Parry; I am a coward, and if I do nothing for myself, what will God do? No, no; I have two arms, Parry, and I have a sword.' And he struck his arm violently with his hand, and took down his sword, which hung against the wall.

'What are you going to do, my lord?'

'What am I going to do, Parry? What every one in my family does. My mother lives on public charity, my sister begs for my mother; I have, somewhere or other, brothers who equally beg for themselves; and I, the eldest, will go and do as all the rest do—I will go and ask charity!'

And with these words, which he finished sharply with a nervous and terrible laugh, the young man girded on his sword, took his hat from the trunk, fastened to his shoulder a black cloak, which he had worn all during his journey, and pressing the two hands of the old man, who watched his proceedings with a look of anxiety,—

'My good Parry,' said he, 'order a fire, drink, eat, sleep, and be happy; let us both be happy, my faithful friend, my only friend. We are rich, as rich as kings!'

He struck the bag of pistols with his clenched hand as he spoke, and it fell heavily to the ground. He resumed that dismal laugh that had so alarmed Parry; and whilst the whole household was screaming, singing, and preparing to install the travellers who had been preceded by their lackeys, he glided out by the principal entrance into the street, where the old man, who had gone to the window, lost sight of him in a moment.

'Monsieur, to one louis, with refreshments and the charge for the horse.'
'Very well, and that of to-day?'

'Ah! there is the difficulty. This is the day of the king's arrival; if the court comes to sleep here, the charge of the day is reckoned. From that it results that three chambers, at two louis each, make six louis. Two louis, monsieur, are not much; but six louis make a great deal.'

The unknown, from red, as we have seen him, became very pale.

He drew from his pocket, with heroic bravery, a purse embroidered with a coat-of-arms, which he carefully concealed in the hollow of his hand. This purse was of a thinness, a flabbiness, a hollowness, which did not escape the eye of Cropole.

The unknown emptied the purse into his hand. It contained three double louis, which amounted to the six louis demanded by the host.

But it was seven that Cropole had required.

He looked, therefore, at the unknown, as much as to say, 'And then?'

'There remains one louis, does there not, master hotelier?'

'Yes, monsieur, but—'

The unknown plunged his hand into the pocket of his haut-de-chausses, and emptied it. It contained a small pocket-book, a gold key, and some silver. With this change, he made up a louis.

'Thank you, monsieur,' said Cropole. 'It now only remains for me to ask whether monsieur intends to occupy his apartments to-morrow, in which case I will reserve them for him; whereas, if monsieur does not mean to do so, I will promise them to some of the king's people who are coming.'

'That is but right,' said the unknown, after a long silence; 'but as I have no more money, as you have seen, and as I yet must retain the apartments, you must either sell this diamond in the city, or hold it in pledge.'

Cropole looked at the diamond so long, that the unknown said, hastily:

'I prefer your selling it, monsieur; for it is worth three hundred pistols. A Jew—are there any Jews in Blois?—would give you two hundred or a hundred and fifty for it—take whatever may be offered for it, if it be no more than the price of your lodging. Begone!'

'Oh! monsieur,' replied Cropole, ashamed of the sudden inferiority which the unknown reflected upon him by this noble and disinterested confidence, as well as by the unalterable patience opposed to so many suspicions and evasions.

The unknown coloured; the idea at once struck him that he was supposed to be poor, and was being insulted.

‘Whilst to-day,’ replied he, coldly, ‘you do not prejudice.’

‘Monsieur, I am a well-meaning man, thank God! and simple hotelier as I am, there is in me the blood of a gentleman. My father was a servant and officer of the late Marechal d’Ancre. God rest his soul!’

‘I do not contest that point with you; I only wish to know, and that quickly, to what your questions tend?’

‘You are too reasonable, monsieur, not to comprehend that our city is small, that the court is about to invade it, that the houses will be overflowing with inhabitants, and that lodgings will consequently obtain considerable prices.’

Again the unknown coloured. ‘Name your terms,’ said he.

‘I name them with scruple, monsieur, because I seek an honest gain, and that I wish to carry on my business without being uncivil or extravagant in my demands. Now the room you occupy is considerable, and you are alone.’

‘That is my business.’

‘Oh! certainly. I do not mean to turn monsieur out.’

The blood rushed to the temples of the unknown; he darted at poor Cropole, the descendant of one of the officers of the Marechal d’Ancre, a glance that would have crushed him down to beneath that famous chimney-slab, if Cropole had not been nailed to the spot by the question of his own proper interests.

‘Do you desire me to go?’ said he. ‘Explain yourself—but quickly!’

‘Monsieur, monsieur, you do not understand me. It is very critical—I know—that which I am doing. I express myself badly, or perhaps, as monsieur is a foreigner, which I perceive by his accent—’

In fact, the unknown spoke with that impetuosity which is the principal character of English accentuation, even among men who speak the French language with the greatest purity.

‘As monsieur is a foreigner, I say, it is perhaps he who does not catch my exact meaning. I wish for monsieur to give up one or two of the apartments he occupies, which would diminish his expenses and ease my conscience. Indeed, it is hard to increase unreasonably the price of the chambers, when one has had the honour to let them at a reasonable price.’

‘How much does the hire amount to since yesterday?’

Chapter VIII

What His Majesty King Louis XIV Was at the Age of Twenty-Two



It has been seen, by the account we have endeavoured to give of it, that the entrée of King Louis XIV into the city of Blois had been noisy and brilliant; his young majesty had therefore appeared perfectly satisfied with it.

On arriving beneath the porch of the Castle of the States, the king met, surrounded by his guards and gentlemen, with S. A. R. the duke, Gaston of Orleans, whose physiognomy, naturally rather majestic, had borrowed on this solemn occasion a fresh lustre and a fresh dignity. On her part, Madame, dressed in her robes of ceremony, awaited, in the interior balcony, the entrance of her nephew. All the windows of the old castle, so deserted and dismal on ordinary days, were resplendent with ladies and lights.

It was then to the sound of drums, trumpets, and vivats, that the young king crossed the threshold of that castle in which, seventy-two years before, Henry III had called in the aid of assassination and treachery to keep upon his head and in his house a crown which was already slipping from his brow, to fall into another family.

All eyes, after having admired the young king, so handsome and so agreeable, sought for that other king of France, much otherwise king than the former, and so old, so pale, so bent, that people called the Cardinal Mazarin.

Louis was at this time endowed with all the natural gifts which make the perfect gentleman; his eye was brilliant, mild, and of a clear azure blue. But

the most skilful physiognomists, those divers into the soul, on fixing their looks upon it, if it had been possible for a subject to sustain the glance of the king—the most skilful physiognomists, we say, would never have been able to fathom the depths of that abyss of mildness. It was with the eyes of the king as with the immense depths of the azure heavens, or with those more terrific, and almost as sublime, which the Mediterranean reveals under the keels of its ships in a clear summer day, a gigantic mirror in which heaven delights to reflect sometimes its stars, sometimes its storms.

The king was short of stature—he was scarcely five feet two inches: but his youth made up for this defect, set off likewise by great nobleness in all his movements, and by considerable address in all bodily exercises.

Certes, he was already quite a king, and it was a great thing to be a king in that period of traditional devotedness and respect; but as, up to that time, he had been but seldom and always poorly shown to the people, as they to whom he was shown saw him by the side of his mother, a tall woman, and *monsieur le cardinal*, a man of commanding presence, many found him so little of a king as to say,—

‘Why, the king is not so tall as *monsieur le cardinal*!’

Whatever may be thought of these physical observations, which were principally made in the capital, the young king was welcomed as a god by the inhabitants of Blois, and almost like a king by his uncle and aunt, *Monsieur* and *Madame*, the inhabitants of the castle.

It must, however, be allowed, that when he saw, in the hall of reception, chairs of equal height for himself, his mother, the cardinal, and his uncle and aunt, a disposition artfully concealed by the semi-circular form of the assembly, *Louis XIV* became red with anger, and looked around him to ascertain by the countenances of those that were present, if this humiliation had been prepared for him. But as he saw nothing upon the impassable visage of the cardinal, nothing on that of his mother, nothing on those of the assembly, he resigned himself, and sat down, taking care to be seated before anybody else.

The gentlemen and ladies were presented to their majesties and *monsieur le cardinal*.

The king remarked that his mother and he scarcely knew the names of any of the persons who were presented to them; whilst the cardinal, on the contrary, never failed, with an admirable memory and presence of mind, to talk to every

Soon the cries of the victims slaughtered in the poultry-yard, the hasty steps of *Madame Cropole* up that little wooden staircase, so narrow and so echoing; the bounding pace of *Pittrino*, who only that morning was smoking at the door with all the phlegm of a Dutchman; all this communicated something like surprise and agitation to the traveller.

As he was rising to make inquiries, the door of his chamber opened. The unknown concluded they were about to introduce the impatiently expected traveller, and made three precipitate steps to meet him.

But, instead of the person he expected, it was *Master Cropole* who appeared, and behind him, in the half-dark staircase, the pleasant face of *Madame Cropole*, rendered trivial by curiosity. She only gave one furtive glance at the handsome gentleman, and disappeared.

Cropole advanced, cap in hand, rather bent than bowing.

A gesture of the unknown interrogated him, without a word being pronounced.

‘*Monsieur*,’ said *Cropole*, ‘I come to ask how—what ought I to say: your lordship, *monsieur le comte*, or *monsieur le marquis*?’

‘Say *monsieur*, and speak quickly,’ replied the unknown, with that haughty accent which admits of neither discussion nor reply.

‘I came, then, to inquire how *monsieur* had passed the night, and if *monsieur* intended to keep this apartment?’

‘Yes.’

‘*Monsieur*, something has happened upon which we could not reckon.’

‘What?’

‘His majesty *Louis XIV* will enter our city to-day and will remain here one day, perhaps two.’

Great astonishment was painted on the countenance of the unknown.

‘The King of France is coming to Blois?’

‘He is on the road, *monsieur*.’

‘Then there is the stronger reason for my remaining,’ said the unknown.

‘Very well; but will *monsieur* keep all the apartments?’

‘I do not understand you. Why should I require less to-day than yesterday?’

‘Because, *monsieur*, your lordship will permit me to say, yesterday I did not think proper, when you chose your lodging, to fix any price that might have made your lordship believe that I prejudged your resources; whilst to-day—’

we say, he whose portrait we have just sketched could not fail of being taken for a gentleman, and of the best class. To ascertain this, there was no necessity to consult anything but his hands, long, slender, and white, of which every muscle, every vein, became apparent through the skin at the least movement, and eloquently spoke of good descent.

This gentleman, then, had arrived alone at Croupole's house. He had taken, without hesitation, without reflection even, the principal apartment which the hotelier had pointed out to him with a rapacious aim, very praiseworthy, some will say, very reprehensible will say others, if they admit that Croupole was a physiognomist, and judged people at first sight.

This apartment was that which composed the whole front of the ancient triangular house; a large salon, lighted by two windows on the first stage, a small chamber by the side of it, and another above it.

Now, from the time he had arrived, this gentleman had scarcely touched any repast that had been served up to him in his chamber. He had spoken but two words to the host, to warn him that a traveller of the name of Parry would arrive, and to desire that, when he did, he should be shown up to him immediately.

He afterwards preserved so profound a silence, that Croupole was almost offended, so much did he prefer people who were good company.

This gentleman had risen early the morning of the day on which this history begins, and had placed himself at the window of his salon, seated upon the ledge, and leaning upon the rail of the balcony, gazing sadly but persistently on both sides of the street, watching, no doubt, for the arrival of the traveller he had mentioned to the host.

In this way he had seen the little cortège of Monsieur return from hunting, then had again partaken of the profound tranquillity of the street, absorbed in his own expectations.

All at once the movement of the crowd going to the meadows, couriers setting out, washers of pavement, purveyors of the royal household, gabbling, scampering shop-boys, chariots in motion, hair-dressers on the run, and pages toiling along, this tumult and bustle had surprised him, but without losing any of that impassible and supreme majesty which gives to the eagle and the lion that serene and contemptuous glance amidst the hurrahs and shouts of hunters or the curious.

one about his estates, his ancestors, or his children, some of whom he named, which enchanted those worthy country gentlemen, and confirmed them in the idea that he alone is truly king who knows his subjects, from the same reason that the sun has no rival, because the sun alone warms and lightens.

The study of the young king, which had begun a long time before, without anybody suspecting it, was continued then, and he looked around him attentively to endeavour to make out something in the physiognomies which had at first appeared the most insignificant and trivial.

A collation was served. The king, without daring to call upon the hospitality of his uncle, had waited for it impatiently. This time, therefore, he had all the honours due, if not to his rank, at least to his appetite.

As to the cardinal, he contented himself with touching with his withered lips a bouillon, served in a golden cup. The all-powerful minister, who had taken her regency from the queen, and his royalty from the king, had not been able to take a good stomach from nature.

Anne of Austria, already suffering from the cancer which six or eight years after caused her death, ate very little more than the cardinal.

For Monsieur, already puffed up with the great event which had taken place in his provincial life, he ate nothing whatever.

Madame alone, like a true Lorrainer, kept pace with his majesty; so that Louis XIV, who, without this partner, might have eaten nearly alone, was at first much pleased with his aunt, and afterwards with M. de Saint-Remy, her maître d'hôtel, who had really distinguished himself.

The collation over, at a sign of approbation from M. de Mazarin, the king arose, and, at the invitation of his aunt, walked about among the ranks of the assembly.

The ladies then observed—there are certain things for which women are as good observers at Blois as at Paris—the ladies then observed that Louis XIV had a prompt and bold look, which premised a distinguished appreciator of beauty. The men, on their part, observed that the prince was proud and haughty, that he loved to look down those who fixed their eyes upon him too long or too earnestly, which gave presage of a master.

Louis XIV had accomplished about a third of his review when his ears were struck with a word which his eminence pronounced whilst conversing with Monsieur.

This word was the name of a woman.

Scarcely had Louis XIV heard this word than he heard, or rather listening to nothing else; and neglecting the arc of the circle which awaited his visit, his object seemed to be to come as quickly as possible to the extremity of the curve.

Monsieur, like a good courtier, was inquiring of monsieur le cardinal after the health of his nieces; he regretted, he said, not having the pleasure of receiving them at the same time with their uncle; they must certainly have grown in stature, beauty and grace, as they had promised to do the last time Monsieur had seen them.

What had first struck the king was a certain constraint in the voices of the two interlocutors. The voice of Monsieur was calm and natural when he spoke thus; while that of M. de Mazarin jumped by a note and a half to reply above the diapason of his usual voice. It might have been said that he wished that voice to strike, at the end of the salon, any ear that was too distant.

‘Monsieur,’ replied he, ‘Mesdemoiselles de Mazarin have still to finish their education: they have duties to fulfil, and a position to make. An abode in a young and brilliant court would dissipate them a little.’

Louis, at this last sentence, smiled sadly. The court was young, it was true, but the avarice of the cardinal had taken good care that it should not be brilliant.

‘You have nevertheless no intention,’ replied Monsieur, ‘to cloister them or make them bourgeoisie?’

‘Not at all,’ replied the cardinal, forcing his Italian pronunciation in such a manner that, from soft and velvety as it was, it became sharp and vibrating; ‘not at all: I have a full and fixed intention to marry them, and that as well as I shall be able.’

‘Parties will not be wanting, monsieur le cardinal,’ replied Monsieur, with a bonhomie worthy of one tradesman congratulating another.

‘I hope not, monsieur, and with reason, as God has been pleased to give them grace, intelligence, and beauty.’

During this conversation, Louis XIV, conducted by Madame, accomplished, as we have described, the circle of presentations.

Chapter VI

The Unknown



Louis founded and recommended by its sign, the hostelry of Maseret Cropole held its way steadily on towards a solid prosperity. It was not an immense fortune that Cropole had in perspective; but he might hope to double the thousand louis d’or left by his father, to make another thousand louis by the sale of his house and stock, and at length to live happily like a retired citizen.

Cropole was anxious for gain, and was half-crazy with joy at the news of the arrival of Louis XIV.

Himself, his wife, Pittirino, and two cooks, immediately laid hands upon all the inhabitants of the dove-cote, the poultry-yard, and the rabbit-hutches; so that as many lamentations and cries resounded in the yards of the hostelry of the Medici as were formerly heard in Rama.

Cropole had, at the time, but one single traveller in his house.

This was a man of scarcely thirty years of age, handsome, tall, austere, or rather melancholy, in all his gestures and looks.

He was dressed in black velvet with jet trimmings; a white collar, as plain as that of the severest Puritan, set off the whiteness of his youthful neck; a small dark-coloured moustache scarcely covered his curled, disdainful lip.

He spoke to people looking them full in the face, without affectation, it is true, but without scruple; so that the brilliancy of his black eyes became so insupportable, that more than one look had sunk beneath his, like the weaker sword in a single combat.

At this time, in which men, all created equal by God, were divided, thanks to prejudices, into two distinct castes, the gentlemen and the commoner, as they are really divided into two races, the black and the white,—at this time,

‘Well, then, you shall order another sign-frame of the smith; you shall paint six physicians, and write underneath “Aux Medici” which makes a very pretty play upon words.’

‘Six physicians! impossible! And the composition?’ cried Pittirino.

‘That is your business—but so it shall be—I insist upon it—it must be so—my macaroni is burning.’

This reasoning was peremptory—Pittirino obeyed. He composed the sign of six physicians, with the legend; the echevin applauded and authorized it.

The sign produced an extravagant success in the city, which proves that poetry has always been in the wrong, before citizens, as Pittirino said.

Cropole, to make amends to his painter-in-ordinary, hung up the nymphs of the preceding sign in his bedroom, which made Madame Cropole blush every time she looked at it, when she was undressing at night.

This is the way in which the pointed-gable house got a sign; and this is how the hostelry of the Medici, making a fortune, was found to be enlarged by a quarter, as we have described. And this is how there was at Blois a hostelry of that name, and had for a painter-in-ordinary Master Pittirino.

‘Mademoiselle Auricule,’ said the princess, presenting to his majesty a fat, fair girl of two-and-twenty, who at a village fete might have been taken for a peasant in Sunday finery,—‘the daughter of my music-mistress.’

The king smiled. Madame had never been able to extract four correct notes from either viol or harpsichord.

‘Mademoiselle Aure de Montalais,’ continued Madame; ‘a young lady of rank, and my good attendant.’

This time it was not the king that smiled; it was the young lady presented, because, for the first time in her life, she heard, given to her by Madame, who generally showed no tendency to spoil her, such an honourable qualification.

Our old acquaintance Montalais, therefore, made his majesty a profound courtesy, the more respectful from the necessity she was under of concealing certain contractions of her laughing lips, which the king might not have attributed to their real cause.

It was just at this moment that the king caught the word which startled him.

‘And the name of the third?’ asked Monsieur.

‘Mary, monseigneur,’ replied the cardinal.

There was doubtless some magical influence in that word, for, as we have said, the king started in hearing it, and drew Madame towards the middle of the circle, as if he wished to put some confidential question to her, but, in reality, for the sake of getting nearer to the cardinal.

‘Madame, my aunt,’ said he, laughing, and in a suppressed voice, ‘my geography-master did not teach me that Blois was at such an immense distance from Paris.’

‘What do you mean, nephew?’ asked Madame.

‘Why, because it would appear that it requires several years, as regards fashion, to travel the distance!—Look at those young ladies!’

‘Well, I know them all.’

‘Some of them are pretty.’

‘Don’t say that too loud, monsieur my nephew; you will drive them wild.’ ‘Stop a bit, stop a bit, dear aunt!’ said the king, smiling; ‘for the second part of my sentence will serve as a corrective to the first. Well, my dear aunt, some of them appear old and others ugly, thanks to their ten-year-old fashions.’

‘But, sire, Blois is only five days’ journey from Paris.’

‘Yes, that is it,’ said the king; ‘two years behind for each day.’

‘Indeed! do you really think so? Well, that is strange! It never struck me.’

‘Now, look, aunt,’ said Louis XIV, drawing still nearer to Mazarin, under the pretext of gaining a better point of view, ‘look at that simple white dress by the side of those antiquated specimens of finery, and those pretentious coiffures. She is probably one of my mother’s maids of honour, though I don’t know her.’

‘Ah! ah! my dear nephew!’ replied Madame, laughing; ‘permit me to tell you that your divinary science is at fault for once. The young lady you honour with your praise is not a Parisian, but a Blaisoise.’

‘Oh, aunt!’ replied the king with a look of doubt.

‘Come here, Louise,’ said Madame.

And the fair girl, already known to you under that name, approached them, timid, blushing, and almost bent beneath the royal glance.

‘Mademoiselle Louise Françoise de la Beaume le Blanc, the daughter of the Marquise de la Vallière,’ said Madame, ceremoniously.

The young girl bowed with so much grace, mingled with the profound timidity inspired by the presence of the king, that the latter lost, while looking at her, a few words of the conversation of Monsieur and the cardinal.

‘Daughter-in-law,’ continued Madame, ‘of M. de Saint-Remy, my maître d’hôtel, who presided over the confection of that excellent daube truffée which your majesty seemed so much to appreciate.’

No grace, no youth, no beauty, could stand out against such a presentation. The king smiled. Whether the words of Madame were a plesantry, or uttered in all innocence, they proved the pitiless immolation of everything that Louis had found charming or poetic in the young girl. Mademoiselle de la Vallière, for Madame and, by rebound, for the king, was, for a moment, no more than the daughter of a man of a superior talent over dindes truffées.

But princes are thus constituted. The gods, too, were just like this in Olympus. Diana and Venus, no doubt, abused the beautiful Alcmena and poor Io, when they condescended for distraction’s sake, to speak, amidst nectar and ambrosia, of mortal beauties, at the table of Jupiter.

Fortunately, Louise was so bent in her reverential salute, that she did not catch either Madame’s words or the king’s smile. In fact, if the poor child, who had so much good taste as alone to have chosen to dress herself in white

To Pittirino he added, ‘His royal highness, Monsieur, who often comes into our city, will not be much pleased to see his illustrious mother so slightly clothed, and he will send you to the oubliettes of the state; for, remember, the heart of that glorious prince is not always tender. You must efface either the two sirens or the legend, without which I forbid the exhibition of the sign. I say this for your sake, Master Cropole, as well for yours, Signor Pittirino.’

What answer could be made to this? It was necessary to thank the echevin for his kindness, which Cropole did. But Pittirino remained downcast and said he felt assured of what was about to happen.

The visitor was scarcely gone when Cropole, crossing his arms, said: ‘Well, master, what is to be done?’

‘We must efface the legend,’ said Pittirino, in a melancholy tone. ‘I have some excellent ivory-black; it will be done in a moment, and we will replace the Medici by the nymphs or the sirens, whichever you prefer.’

‘No,’ said Cropole, ‘the will of my father must be carried out. My father considered—’

‘He considered the figures of the most importance,’ said Pittirino.

‘He thought most of the legend,’ said Cropole.

‘The proof of the importance in which he held the figures,’ said Pittirino, ‘is that he desired they should be likenesses, and they are so.’

‘Yes; but if they had not been so, who would have recognized them without the legend? At the present day even, when the memory of the Blaisois begins to be faint with regard to these two celebrated persons, who would recognize Catherine and Mary without the words “To the Medici?”’

‘But the figures?’ said Pittirino, in despair; for he felt that young Cropole was right. ‘I should not like to lose the fruit of my labour.’

‘And I should not wish you to be thrown into prison, and myself into the oubliettes.’

‘Let us efface “Medici”,’ said Pittirino, supplicatingly.

‘No,’ replied Cropole, firmly. ‘I have got an idea, a sublime idea—your picture shall appear, and my legend likewise. Does not “Medici” mean doctor, or physician, in Italian?’

‘Yes, in the plural.’